

# ***The Social Radars***

## **S1: Tracy Young, Co-Founder & CEO of PlanGrid**

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Jessica: I'm Jessica Livingston, and Carolynn Levy and I are The Social Radars. In this podcast, we talked to some of the most successful founders in Silicon Valley about how they did it. Carolynn and I have been working together to help thousands of startups at Y Combinator for almost 20 years. Come be a fly on the wall as we talk to founders and learn their true stories.

Today we're talking with Tracy Young, one of the most successful female founders so far. Y Combinator funded her startup PlanGrid in the winter of 2012. PlanGrid revolutionized the construction industry by getting blueprints off paper and on to tablets.

You'll hear about how they got started, how they lost a co-founder to cancer in the first few weeks of Y Combinator, how they sold the company for almost a billion dollars in 2018, and how she's now gone on to start a new startup called TigerEye with her husband and PlanGrid co-founder, Ralph Gootee. Enjoy.

We are here today with Tracy Young, who was a co-founder of PlanGrid and is now a co-founder of a new company she's started called TigerEye. Tracy, great to see you.

Tracy: It is so good to see both of you.

Jessica: Good to see you too. Thank you for coming today. I always have to double check when the year was that Y Combinator funded someone because it's now getting to be a long time. It was in 2012. We funded PlanGrid. And that was, as I used to describe it, blueprints for the Cloud, construction blueprints for the Cloud. But before that, though, I want to hear how you started PlanGrid. I know you were a construction engineer trained in that, and you had a job in construction.

Tracy: Just like any 17 year old, you don't really know what you want to do with your life, but here I am enrolled in university, and I was pretty good at math. I liked buildings, but I knew I couldn't be an architect. At least I didn't believe that my artistic and creative skills were good enough to have a career there. I studied civil engineering. And at some point around sophomore year, there's really two career paths, at least at the university that I was at that I could choose from. One, I could sit behind a desk and crunch numbers all day and make the math work, which it should work, or I could be on a job site helping out with construction and managing construction projects. And that just sounded way more fun than sitting behind a desk for the rest of my life.

Jessica: Yeah, I tend to agree with that. Although, I bet that there were some crazy things that happened on the construction sites. I don't know that much about construction, but I have lived through a home renovation, and I can imagine a lot went wrong. I remember you saying... it was early on when I met you, and maybe it was during the interview, I remember you were saying one of the problems you were trying to solve with PlanGrid was just taking these blueprints that were so enormous and so expensive to print. I think, didn't you say they were like \$20,000 to just make a change? You have to run off \$20,000 worth of new blueprints for the teams?

Tracy: It's really expensive to print on 36 inch by 48 inch paper.

Jessica: Oh, my gosh. You would carry them around in a shopping cart. Is that right? Do I have that story right?

Tracy: Yeah. It wasn't a shopping cart. It's one of these Rubbermaid tables that have a bottom compartment, and it's on wheels. I'm solid muscle and I couldn't carry my blueprints, and my foreman bought me one of these carts to lay my blueprints on. There was a little cup holder for my pencils and rulers, and I would wheel around this shopping cart around the job site like I didn't stick out like a sore thumb.

Jessica: You would make a change to the design and have to spend all this money and hand out... wheel around your new versions of the blueprints to everyone. What was it that inspired you guys to start your own company to fix things? Clearly, it sounds like something was broken.

Tracy: 2010, 2011, anyone in construction knew that we were constantly building off of outdated drawings. And it's because version control is hard, and it's especially hard when the paper is physically made bigger and there's just a lot of sheets of them, thousands at a time for a hospital project that I was on. And then there's also 500 other people on the job site. You can email their project managers, but how does the project manager ensure that they get it out to the formens and the carpenters and the plumbers out on time when they're building every single day?

The version control problem was very obvious. Everyone was experiencing it. My co-founder Ryan and I were working in construction. He stands in line for hours and hours and gets the first generation iPad, and we're looking at it over beers and we are like, "This is perfect for construction. We can't take a computer out into the field, but this is lightweight. We can totally use this for our job." The first thing we did was try to load our own construction documents onto it. Then this box comes up and it says, "Out of memory."

And Ryan, I remember, was dancing all over the room. He was so excited and he said, "We should build this." And I remember looking at him, it's like, "Yeah, it's a good idea, but clearly, we're not software developers. We're construction

engineers." Over the next year, we would convince our incredibly-talented software engineer friends to join our project.

Jessica: How did you convince them? Because you guys had all these pain points and had this domain expertise, how did you convince them to join you?

Tracy: Oh, man. I think everyone knew it was a good enough idea because they couldn't believe how stupid we were running our construction projects. I think probably where they were leaning towards for all of us was just like this fun project we could work together on, and we get to see each other on a weekly basis and just catch up and do this fun thing on the side.

Jessica: You convinced your programmer friends to join you and you quit your... No, I think I read you... Did you get laid off from your job?

Tracy: No, no, no, I didn't. I was hired as engineer number 1000 in 2008. And then the construction industry would see the highest unemployment rates in the next few years because of the housing crisis and the economic crisis. Over the next few years, my company, this general contracting company that I was working for, would have only 300 employees left.

Jessica: Oh, wow.

Tracy: And I was still there. I think for a bit I convinced myself that I must have these amazing engineering skills, because I'm still here and I've survived five rounds of layoffs. But in hindsight, I must have been one of the lowest-paid engineers.

Carolynn: I was just going to say, you were the cheapest, you were kept because you were the cheapest. Which company was it?

Tracy: Rudolph and Sletten Construction.

Carolynn: Okay. Yeah.

Jessica: You quit. Did you quit to start the company or did you work on it as a side project at first?

Tracy: Let me think about this. We quit our jobs to work on PlanGrid. The industry was pretty depressing at the time. All of us were engineers, we were all incredibly frugal. We told ourselves we would give ourselves 18 months. That's how much personal runway we had.

Jessica: Oh, okay.

Tracy: We'd work on it until the 18 months go by and we'll see what happens after that. Lucky for us, we got funded by Y Combinator. We got good advice, and we

launched our product into the world. People were paying for it and so we just kept doing it for another eight years.

Jessica: Wow. You applied to YC, had you launched... I think you had launched at that point, or had you not?

Tracy: We were in beta. We had our friends using it.

Jessica: Okay, so you made it fit on the iPad, basically.

Tracy: Yeah. Yeah, we made it work.

Jessica: I remember your guys' interview, and I remember thinking, "Oh, I love when people come fixing a problem that their domain experts on." And you had the engineering experts, construction experts, and the programmers and it was such an unsexy idea, but we were like, "This team is great and the idea's great and they can charge people right away. Let's fund them."

Tracy: We had a dramatic pitch too. We walked into the room, we knew we only had 10 minutes. I was carrying all the blueprints, and I'm the smallest of the team. Then I just threw it on the table in front of you guys and one of my co-founders iPad and it's like, "We're going to replace this with this."

Carolynn: Oh, that's excellent.

Jessica: I do remember it was dramatic, and it was very clear, like, "Gosh, blueprints do seem so outdated." And that definitely helped.

Carolynn: Did RTM like it too? Because that's the real test. Do you remember Jessica?

Jessica: I don't remember, because he doesn't usually say that much. I think he was probably like, "Sounds good." We funded you. Let's talk about Antoine because that's a major part of your history and a sad part. That's when I remember meeting your co-founder Antoine, who came to the interview. Did he come to the first dinner? And then he passed away soon after. For you guys that must have been... as a good friend of yours, it must have been devastating. But you were also in the middle of this intense company building period where you had to focus, you had to keep going. Were you inspired to keep going to make this a success?

Tracy: Our co-founder, Antoine Hersen was diagnosed with a rare form of cancer at 27 and he was battling it for a long time. And I guess as I'm talking about this now, it was one of the reasons why it was really easy for all of us to quit our jobs. We wanted to be together with him, work on this fun project. We moved into Hacker House in Sunnyvale. We lived out of there, worked out there together for his last days. He was programming until his last days. I'm sure there is still Antoine code somewhere in PlanGrid at Autodesk right now. And it was crazy.

We're going through Y Combinator, we're really excited. Our best friend was dying. There's hospice care coming to our house, and that was the start of PlanGrid.

Jessica: Wow. Oh, my gosh.

Tracy: I remember my face was just really rough for an entire year because we were just crying so much. We would do demos, we would talk about product, we would talk about bugs, and then we would just go to a corner and cry. We did this for months and months because we missed him so much.

Carolynn: Was he like a college friend? How long had you known him?

Tracy: Yeah. Yeah. Let's see. Three of us went to college together, three of us were dating, now married, and two of us had worked together. That's how we knew each other.

Carolynn: You guys were all really tight.

Tracy: Yeah.

Carolynn: Really, really tight.

Jessica: That was a very sad but probably really-

Tracy: It's not unique to us. The number of founders that just have gone through YC who have either been diagnosed with cancer or their co-founder has cancer or their loved one has cancer, the number of people that have reached out to me over the years knowing this story, it just happened all the time.

Jessica: Oh, wow. Wow. I don't think I realized that. I obviously knew about your story. It must have inspired you guys after he passed away to say, "We are going to make this a success."

Tracy: Gosh. At least in the early days. I think many of us were very much motivated by, "We're going to keep going for him."

Jessica: Now you guys... you go through... well I see it's just a three-month intense period. This horrible thing happens. We have demo day at the end. I hope Paul will give me retroactive permission to say this, but I was looking just at the PlanGrid, internal notes that we had from way back when. Paul had a comment that said, "VCs didn't like them. Not sure why." It sounds like maybe after demo day did you struggle a little bit with venture capitalists? Because you guys were making money pretty early on I think.

Tracy: Yeah. I didn't actually go fundraise. I was in charge of sales and Ryan, my co-founder, went to fundraise. And we basically told him to spend the next

month fundraising. It's okay if we don't get investment, we're going to keep going. We can build this with just us. And he would come home and he would do his best to keep a brave face on and get back to work. But we're just like, "Don't tell us about anything. I don't want to get emotional over..." We're still mourning at this time. We're really trying to get the product out. And so Ryan would come back and it didn't matter what a shitty day he had, he came back and he just went back to work. But luckily we were able to convince enough people, get everyone to spend \$10,000, eventually you can get to 1.5 million of a seed round. And that's what he did.

Jessica: Which was a respectable seed round back in 2012. Let's face it. You really told Ryan, "Go do your thing. Do not keep us updated."

Tracy: We knew that people wouldn't understand what [inaudible 00:14:01]. I think after demo day, at least back then, there would be this mingling with the investors. We were already hearing feedback. It's like, "Okay, this seems cool, but construction people aren't going to be able to use an iPad." And then you try to explain to them, it's like these people work in dangerous conditions day in and day out, and they figure out how to go home to their families safely every day. They're going to be able to freaking use an iPad. But you see their faces and you see their response and their body language. It's like, "Oh, this isn't resonating. They don't get it." Well, that's too bad for them because we're going to keep building this.

Jessica: Which is the best attitude to have, frankly. Was that the biggest pushback, "Ugh, construction people won't adopt this," that you won't get them to make the changes?

Tracy: It was even stupider than that, it was like they're going to break the iPad.

Carolynn: Wow.

Jessica: Oh, wow. That's a good one.

Carolynn: That's pretty lame.

Jessica: Oh my gosh. You raised the seed round, and I think... correct me if I'm wrong, but you were profitable from an early point because you were charging customers for this. When you would meet with a customer, heading up sales at that time, could you tell that people were like, "Thank you for making this for me. You are about to revolutionize my job?"

Tracy: Yeah, anyone who saw PlanGrid in 2012, 2013 loved it. Just in its most basic simplistic form. It's like you have no idea what is up-to-date right now in the field and we're about to help you solve that. And by the way, it's only going to take us a day. Just give us all of your documents and we'll version control them for you,

and it'll just show up on your device. It was a no-brainer, especially for the cost. We of course didn't have the right pricing and packaging for a long time.

Carolynn: I was just going to say, how long did it take you to get the pricing right? I was just going to ask that.

Tracy: For whatever these hospitals were that we were selling to at the time, these commercial projects, let's say \$100 million projects and PlanGrid at the time was only 200 bucks a year. Eventually the price would slowly go up over the next 10 years. It also got more powerful.

Jessica: I'm going to fast-forward for a second to 2018. You're working on this diligently for six or seven years or whatever, and you sell for 875 million dollars. I have to say, I remember feeling like you did not get enough publicity for that acquisition. I truly think that. I remember within YC it was a huge acquisition.

Tracy: We didn't need the publicity. We were at that point we're going through integration hell. And so we had other things on our mind.

Jessica: I read a couple of things in this article in Forbes I guess that came out recently. And one of them was that you stayed at Autodesk, you then both left and were going to take your parents traveling and your family, you had a few kids at that point and COVID hits.

Tracy: Oh my gosh, we retired from Autodesk in March 2020. Can you believe that?

Carolynn: I can't believe that.

Tracy: We were going to go on a cruise. We were going to go on a [inaudible 00:17:12] romantic cruise for a month.

Carolynn: Oh fun.

Jessica: Where? To where?

Tracy: And I'm sure it was going to land in the UK somewhere. And luckily that was canceled. And because you remember at the time people were stuck on cruise ships dying.

Carolynn: In Oakland, like the Diamond Princess. I remember it well.

Tracy: And so we didn't actually do that. Instead we just hunkered down and had a ton of time. And you wake up one day going at a certain speed for 10 years and then you wake up and it's like, "Wow, we've just stopped doing the thing we've been doing that's been all consuming in our life." And what that gave us was just a lot of time to reflect. It also kept us from refreshing on COVID news and how many cases were in the Bay Area. That helped keep ourselves sane. We did another, I

guess, crazy thing, which was dissect every minute of the startup we had just built.

Jessica: Well that's what I read. That you guys dissected all the minutiae of what you had done with PlanGrid. And what I'm curious to know is what were the things you wanted to keep in a new company and what were some of the things you definitely wanted to change?

Tracy: Those conversations would become the foundation of our core values and another document that we have called our commitments to each other. I can actually read them to you because I'm a huge fan of them obviously. But the number one thing about startups and any company that's building together is the team. I think for a long time I thought, especially as our team grew to nearly 500 people, you just get all kinds of flavors of people, experiences, high egos. And I thought it was my job to tolerate oversized egos. But the message that sends the team is that as long as you're performing for Tracy, you can get away with murder, you can get away with being an asshole. And so we only had a handful of these folks, but boy were they damaging to our culture. And this time around our core values and our commitments to each other are written in a way that is so crystal clear, we will hire and fire by these values that we've set.

Jessica: Have you had to fire someone whose ego was too big for your new company?

Tracy: Not yet. And the company's new and I have hand-picked them specifically for talent, hard Work and humility. Not yet. But I'm sure the day will come.

Carolynn: Do you think you're a better recruiter, hirer, because you've taken the time to set all this out and write it all down? Because hiring is really, really hard. And firing is obviously very hard too, but do you know what you're looking for now when you're just meeting someone?

Tracy: Yeah.

Carolynn: Do you think you can spot it?

Tracy: Yeah, yeah, for sure. I remember when I did my CFO search in 2015 and I probably met 20 CFO candidates. And the first thing I did was look at them and was like, "What do you do all day?" Because my board was, "I need a CFO." We've been doing finances for the last four years. I think I'm doing a good job. And we just had no idea what we actually needed to do as a company in terms of compliance for this role as an example. I think if I were to look back when we first started PlanGrid, I was probably 26 years old and I was a construction engineer, none of us were managers. Like no one great and fantastic wanted to work for us. I think this time around we definitely get to see better resumes. There's also so many people that have come and gone at PlanGrid that we can recruit from as well. It is just easier because we just have more experience now.



Jessica: What else are you being more deliberate about?

Tracy: PlanGrid was obviously built for mobile first. We were one of the first enterprise solutions to launch on the app store. We were one of the first enterprise solutions to launch on Google Play and the Windows store. And we would go through platform parity hell, because of the timing of the releases. Android and Windows were always so far behind iOS and web. Just because we were constantly catching up. When we built new features, we'd go to our users and say it's on iOS, it's going to come out in web in the next few weeks. And then if you're on an Android device or on a Windows device, just wait two years.

Jessica: Oh my gosh.

Carolynn: Oh wow. The Windows users, maybe that's sending them a message.

Tracy: There's just this combinatorial explosion of problems with building across platforms that way. You think about every help article and now we have to have four versions of every help article for each platform. This time around we're also trying to make better technology and infrastructure decisions. In grid is built on one cross platform code base. We hit publish, it goes to all the platforms. It's one help article. It's one team building out everything instead of four. Which trades our R&D costs way down.

Carolynn: How does the pacing or the timing differ from PlanGrid to TigerEye? Did you feel like you were under pressure in PlanGrid to iterate quickly and push things out and there was just more pressure, it was your first time. With TigerEye are you more deliberate? It's like, "Eh, we'll get it when we get it because we want it to be perfect."

Tracy: We are improving the product every single week. I think the biggest difference is, you said the word deliberate. We are more deliberate, more strategic in making better foundational decisions so that we're not stuck in this tech debt for the rest of our lives. At PlanGrid, we knew what products and features would help us gain market share in the competitive landscape. We knew how the products should look to be the winner. But many times we didn't build out those features because we were prioritizing \$10,000 of ARR, because a customer's like, "If you just build this other thing just for me, I'll buy X amount of more PlanGrid." And so we were always prioritizing some small amount of revenue to stay alive. We have the benefit of raising as second time founders and we don't have to make those trade-offs. We get to make smarter decisions now. But the pressure's definitely still here.

Jessica: How many employees do you have right now?

Tracy: We're a team of 13.

Jessica: Is going around to VCs easier this time? I know you said you didn't do it the first time, but generally speaking, do you feel like because you guys have had this earlier success that people... at least that people are willing to meet.

Tracy: Everyone we have on board are old PlanGrid investors, so the conversations are much quicker.

Jessica: Oh, that's great. That's good because that also suggests that you had great investors at PlanGrid.

Tracy: YC led our seed round and Gary with Initialize, now IC led our series A.

Jessica: Oh, that's great.

Carolynn: Kept it in the fam.

I like it.

Jessica: Speaking of family, the other thing I read in this article... Because I'm interested in this because I started Y Combinator with my partner, spouse, and you and Ralph are married. You were dating when you started the company. And in this article the reporter said, "Can you give advice about starting a company with your partner?" And you said, "Don't do it." Did you say, "Don't do it!" Or did you say, "Don't do it." How did you mean? I couldn't tell exactly how you meant.

Tracy: If you have the choice... because relationships are so hard. If you have the choice to not start a company with your significant other, my advice would be to not do it. Why complicate relationships and marriage that way? But with that said, Jessica and Carolynn and me, we are all examples that you can stay in your marriage, hopefully have a successful one and also work together professionally.

Jessica: It's true, all three of us work or did work closely with our spouses. And I think that it was pretty successful or it was successful for all three of us. And you said... I really could relate to what you said in this article. You said, Tracy, "We have clearly defined roles." And I know when anyone ever asked me about working with Paul, that was it. We worked so well together and one of the reasons was because we did have clearly defined roles and he was technical. He had done a startup and I did things that he had no interest in doing, but we would come together on the big things. And that worked out.

Tracy: We had this diagram with of course a lot of overlap in the center, but we also had these massive spaces on the outskirts for each one of us. And there was very little overlap there. And what that meant was we could just get more work done without stepping over each other. Because the challenge is, when you're fighting over whatever it is that's stupid... like you're fighting over pixels. Someone's got to make a call because you can't be stuck there fighting for weeks. You just have

to make a decision and move on. And it was very easy for us to do that because of the clear delineation of responsibilities and expertise.

Jessica: Yeah. Well this is a really small little detail, but I've never really talked about it with anyone. I feel like you're starting this company with your partner and you have kids, which of course adds whole new layers of stress and chaos to your life. I feel like if you work with your partner, they understand... you just can just be this amazing team. They can understand if you have to go to that meeting and they have to take the kids or you swap. I just feel like there's this extra level of compassion that they have for the whole thing. I don't know if that makes any sense.

Tracy: Yeah, it's true in our case too.

Carolynn: We find that we can say, "This situation's really frustrating to me." And you don't have to describe why because your spouse is like, "Yeah, I know to me too." Because they just know the parties and the situation and the context and the background and that just makes that conversation like, "All right. Yeah, I'm feeling the empathy."

Jessica: You and Ralph started this new company and you're not talking much about it at this point because you haven't officially launched, is that right?

Tracy: No, we haven't launched yet. We're still in stealth, so I can't talk much about it. But what I can say is that I get the privilege to work with our team and our customers and they come from all walks of life. They are Boomers, they're Gen X, they're Gen Z, they're Millennials. It is so freaking obvious to me that this Reddit, TikTok generation is not going to stand for any of the legacy enterprise solutions. Because it is hard to use, it is slow, it makes us less productive. And TigerEye is trying to solve a piece of it.

Jessica: I love it. I love when something's broken, but it's embedded in the world and people come along and disrupt that. Which sounds like what you're going to do.

Tracy: I think success for us would be TigerEye setting the bar for what modern enterprise software looks like.

Carolynn: Lofty goal. I like it.

Jessica: And how long have you been working on it now?

Tracy: About a year, maybe a little less than a year. I have a newborn... not newborn anymore, she just turned one, so I had to take some time off.

Jessica: But three kids under the age of...

Tracy: Four, Four young kids I know.

Jessica: Under the age of four.

Tracy: I looked up and I wasn't getting any younger and I wanted a big family, so I just popped them out.

Jessica: Oh wow. That is so exciting, but gosh hectic. I can imagine that's hectic.

Tracy: And the only way it works is to be able to be a mom and to be able to be a founder is I have a partner that shares 50% of the childcare and household duties with me. It's not just about equality in the workplace, but it's also equality in the household. And I'm very lucky my mom and dad live with me, so I get some help there and I pay for nannies.

Jessica: Oh wow.

Tracy: That is the cost of working full-time as a co-founder because there are certain events that have to happen like drop off and pickup from daycare and preschool that I can't be there for, or my husband can't be there for. And so we hire someone to do that work.

Jessica: I struggled with this... Now, it was like 10 years ago. I was struggling with this, but I remember asking Diane Green, how were you such a successful founder? And you had two young kids as you were doing this. And she said, "I used to outsource everything that I could at home." I think she had a cook, she had a gardener, she had someone to come in and clean the house. I'm sure she had a nanny so that she'd be at work and focused on that and when she'd come home, she'd be totally focused on her kids and spending time with the kids. But everything else was outsourced. And I think, yeah, there's just some things... you can't be in three different places at one time, so you have to have the infrastructure to be able to support pickups and drop-offs and things like that. And kids being sick. I remember that's what threw me off, having kids home sick unexpectedly.

Carolynn: I actually thought the harder part of the balance was, not the physical stuff, but the responding to birthday parties, getting the birthday gift purchased and the bake sale that someone said you had to bring something to. And by the way, you got a volunteer at the school library because everyone's doing volunteer hours. That stuff to me was harder than the logistics. Harder to balance. Because it seems like there's so much of it.

Jessica: There's a lot of stuff.

Carolynn: When the whole class gets invited to every single birthday party.

Jessica: But you have your parents, Tracy, that live at your house with you.

Tracy: Yeah, they're probably with us, let's say 90% of the time.

Jessica: That is amazing.

Tracy: Kids are the luckiest to get a grandma and grandpa to spoil them every single day.

Jessica: It's a very special relationship. I was raised by my grandmother in part and we were very close and it's a wonderful, wonderful relationship that a lot of kids don't get because they don't live very close to parents. I think it's wonderful.

Tracy: Yeah, and I know I'm extremely lucky on this front.

Jessica: Did you ever take that cruise?

Tracy: No, no. With COVID still out in the world and seeing what happened that summer of 2020, I'm not sure if I'll ever step forward on a cruise ever again.

Carolynn: John and I decided we're never going on a cruise ever. We've been on one and we're like, "That's off the bucket list. We don't ever have to get on a cruise ship ever again."

Jessica: Do you have a big family vacation on your bucket list at least or somewhere that you want to take your kids?

Tracy: Not yet. I did tell one of them that I would take them to Disneyland at some point and I doubt he has forgotten that. I've got to make that trip at some point. If he's tall enough for the rides. He probably would like it even if he couldn't get on.

Carolynn: I was going to say Magic Kingdom's is the Magic Kingdom. You should just go anyway. When you're doing this second startup do you ever hit a moment where you look at each other and you're like, "Well, that will be our third startup?"

Tracy: Oh, no, no, no, no, no. This is for sure my last software company. Hopefully with some luck I get to do this for another 10, 20 years. But this is for sure the last one. And actually that has helped with some recruiting as well. It's like if you've ever thought about working with us again, this is the last one, this is it.

Carolynn: Oh wow. That's a great pitch. It's now or never for Tracy and Ralph.

Jessica: Interesting. Although I always worry about saying really...

Tracy: I know, I know. But as you guys know, building a startup is really hard. And on some days I have woken up and kids have COVID right now and I don't know, there's flooding around here and trees are down and... and then there's work to do and it's just like, "Wait, why did I do this again? Remind me, please."

Jessica: What do you do for yourself? For me time, even if it's a 15-minute break. What is your go-to relaxation, get out of my life thing, technique?

Tracy: I pour myself a cup of tea and I listen to jazz. Just one or two songs and then I try to sun myself in a quiet room and it's really helpful.

Carolynn: That's very peaceful.

Jessica: That is peaceful.

Carolynn: Get a breath.

Jessica: And simple.

Tracy: Yeah.

Carolynn: And yeah, and simple.

Jessica: Do you exercise at all?

Tracy: I should. I try to walk. That's my exercise right now is I try to walk, let's say a mile a day.

Carolynn: That's same with me. That's like the simplest, cheapest and you get a lot of fresh air.

Tracy: Yeah. Got to do it every single day though.

Carolynn: And it doesn't hurt your knees.

Jessica: And it allows you to have ideas.

Carolynn: Yes.

Jessica: If you're not talking with someone on your walk, if you're going alone.

Tracy: I work out a lot of problems in my head or at least I am able to silence my mind on the stuff that I can't take care of.

Carolynn: Yeah, I'm the same way. I relate.

Jessica: And do you guys have an office at this point or are you all working from home offices?

Tracy: This new company, TigerEye is 100% remote.

Jessica: And are you going to stay that way do you think?

Tracy: We are probably going to stay that way because it's working, but it doesn't come free. There's a lot of things we have to do. We have to throw a lot more in-person offsite, so we get the connection and we get to break bread together and everyone has to have amazing communication skills.

Carolynn: You might have already might already known this, but Zapier and GitLab are remote first, remote only YC companies, and they have all of their best practices published and publicly available. You can see all about how they're doing this whole remote only... You probably already know all this, but just in case you guys...

Tracy: These guys were doing remote work before the pandemic. Before it was cool to be remote.

Carolynn: Exactly. They have perfected it.

Tracy: [inaudible 00:36:27]. I'm such a fan of GitLab. In fact, we run our entire R&D side on GitLab.

Carolynn: Oh wow. Yeah.

Jessica: Oh wow.

Carolynn: They are a really good company.

Jessica: I have a last question because I remember... YC funded you in 2012 and then in 2015 you were a speaker at one of the very early female founders conferences. And you gave such a fabulous talk. I remember just being so energized after your talk and thinking, "Oh, Tracy just killed it out there and was so psyched." Do you remember that talk?

Tracy: I remember that talk.

Jessica: Roughly. Do you remember giving it? Were you nervous back then?

Tracy: Oh, I'm still nervous every time I speak, I'm nervous.

Jessica: But you were such an inspiration. You continue to be an inspiration to women out there who might be thinking that they would like to start a startup or maybe have just recently started one. Any specific advice for them that you want to share?

Tracy: Starting TigerEye is partly activism for me. Year over year I see the funding stats, I see the news, even meeting founders and over and over again I remember asking myself, "Wait, where are all the women?" And so part of it is, "Okay, I'm going to step up to the plate and do this." Plus there's these problems in our enterprise software that I just want to see changed. The advice I would give to

everyone is if you are not happy with the status quo, if you are not happy with the products that you have to use, be the change that you want to see. Step up to the plate and do it. What's the worst that can happen? If you fail you'll learn a ton along the way and you'll be a better person afterwards.

Jessica: Take the risk.

Tracy: Because it's actually not that risky in the end. You do have to be in a place where you're keeping your personal burn low because more likely than not, you're not going to be paying yourselves for a long time.

Jessica: I think that's actually excellent advice. As long as you have some savings to survive, you can pay the rent, you can cover your expenses, if you keep your personal burn low and you have enough expenses even for a year, I think. The 18 months that you guys had was great, but I think even if you had enough for a year, you could accomplish a lot in a year. And there's a lot of different funding sources out there these days. Much more than there were in 2012.

Carolynn: For sure.

Tracy: Especially for people who have never liked their bosses. Just be your own.

Jessica: I love it. All right, we'll end there on that very positive note. Be your own boss. Thank you so much for coming. It was so fun chatting with you and catching up. And I can't wait to hear about the launch when TigerEye launches and it sounds like you're doing a lot of exciting new things with it.

Tracy: Oh, it's so nice seeing you too.

Carolynn: Hope your family gets better soon.

Tracy: They will. Thank you.

Jessica: All right, bye.

Carolynn: Thanks Tracy. Bye.

Jessica: Thank you.

That was so much fun.

Carolynn: Oh, it was so great.

Jessica: Catching up with Tracy.

Carolynn: Yeah, it was great.



Jessica: I love talking to her. She's so confident yet humble. There needs to be a word for that. I wonder what the word would be.

Carolynn: I really liked their principles too, about being so deliberate and careful about who they hire. That makes so much sense to me.

Jessica: Well actually, I know it sounds a little bit strange, but I really think it could be a trend going forward to be just a bit more explicit about what is important to you as founders. We always tell YC founders, "Ugh, don't worry about getting a board of directors. Don't worry about that. Just focus on the product." But if you are at the point where you're starting to hire people, I think being very clear about your culture and what's important to you as founders for your culture and explicitly stating that on your website and explicitly stating it in the interviews so that you are very clear from the get go. I think that that could be a really important thing in terms of matching people up with the right company and the right employees.

Carolynn: I think that's all right. I think though it's actually what you said just a second ago, which is that the ability to pull that off does require a lot of confidence because you're going to be held accountable if you've been public... or not even public, public, but very explicit within the company that this is how you're going to hire and this is what your principles and ethics are. And confidence is hard to come by, especially if you're a brand new founder. You're so unsure of how things are going to go and everything's new. And so I totally agree with you. I hope it's a trend and maybe it will be, but it does require someone with a lot of confidence to pull that off.

Jessica: And vigilance. Plus, I think it's hard, as your company gets bigger and bigger and bigger and you're committed to not hiring assholes, you will have an asshole in there. And they probably... you know it, but you actually do something about it.

Carolynn: Exactly.

Jessica: I guess my point is it's easier to do something about it if you're very explicit.

Carolynn: Because you're probably talking about it and you're probably hyper aware of it. And I think the problem is when you have an asshole-creep, because you could have an asshole-creep.

Jessica: And can we just discuss for one second that her kid has COVID right now and I think her parents do too, and how hard it must be to be working on a startup with three kids under four.

Carolynn: Yeah, it's crazy.

Jessica: Oh my gosh.

Carolynn: God bless.

Jessica: I know. And it's such a great role model. When she pulls this off and can say, "Look, I did this and I have this great family." It'll be so amazing. I love it.

Carolynn: Yeah. Yeah. Same.

Jessica: All right, well we will talk next week at our next interview.

Carolynn: Talk next week.

Jessica: Bye.

Carolynn: Bye.